2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna

Email

Phone / Teléfono

Grade / Grado

School / Escuela

Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- Father / Padre
- Grandfather / Abuelo
- Stepdad / Padrasto
- Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

What my dad means to me is a lot. He hasn't always been there but he has for the past couple years. While i was with my mom my step dad showed me how to be respectful and he taught me things about the boy body my dad was not there to show me. I love my step dad and my dad but my step dad showed me how to be a young man. When my step dad passed I started to follow in his footsteps. Everything he taught me and showed me I try to do or keep with me to this day. My dad Robert is a good dad though both mario and Robert showed me different qualities. Mario showed me the ways to be a young man but my dad is here now. Our relationship isnt the same as it once was but he is trying his best. These past 3 years have been interesting. A lot of stuff has happened between me and my dad but I know he is trying his best and he is showing me how to live in big cities and how to be a social person. The qualities of being a good dad/father figure should be to show your kid love and how to be a mature respectful individual. Being a good father figure is not only being there for the kid, it's showing them how to grow up and how to move on from difficult times. The qualities of being a good father isnt buying love or spoiling a kid, it's showing the kid how to live life and how to react to problems little kids don't know how to react to. You don't have to be tough on the kid but show them the ways of life and how to be respectful

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.